

Education, Tradition, and the Core Curriculum

I.

Concerns about multicultural diversity, cultural awareness, and the perspectives of once-marginalized traditions occupy a large part of contemporary conversation about higher education. Those concerns are likely to be intensified as the revolutionizing impact of recent work in contemporary moral philosophy gains greater influence. I refer primarily to Alasdair MacIntyre's three major efforts which have appeared over the course of the last decade: *After Virtue*, *Whose Justice? Which Rationality?*, and *Three Rival Versions of Moral Inquiry*.¹

MacIntyre has argued that there is no tradition-neutral way to evaluate rival traditions and thus no neutral way to write the history of different cultures or to investigate them. There can be, then, no tradition-neutral education, according to MacIntyre's argument.

If MacIntyre is right, then the notion of a core curriculum is misconceived, at least when understood as a group of courses aimed at acquainting students with a body of knowledge and skills with which all educated people ought to be familiar. There are no tradition-neutral requirements for what "educated" people ought to know, because different traditions have different pictures of what mature and hence well-educated members of those traditions are like. The education necessary to produce a Hume will be different from that needed to produce a Nietzsche, and from that for an Aquinas, or a Confucius, or a Gandhi.

¹ *After Virtue* (Notre Dame, IN: University of Notre Dame Press) 1981, 1984; *Whose Justice? Which Rationality?* (Notre Dame, IN: University of Notre Dame Press, 1988); *Three Rival Traditions of Moral Enquiry* (Notre Dame: University of Notre Dame Press, 1990)

In what follows I will attempt discuss the nature of education in a way which, while not itself tradition-neutral, can serve nonetheless as a framework within which a wide variety of traditions can locate their educational goals. The analysis I will offer is a variation of the Platonic view that education is the pursuit of the good life. I will discuss the nature of the good, and the nature of education as both a part of and a means to the good life. In a way which I think will provide a rationale for MacIntyre's conclusion that education is inescapably tradition-bound, I will sketch the outline of an argument that the good life is discoverable only within the context of traditions. I will conclude with some remarks about the implications of that conclusion for the nature of higher education and for core curricula.

II.

Recent attempts in moral philosophy to uncover the nature of well-being—such as those of utilitarians Peter Railton and James Griffin—have focused on what have come to be called informed-desire accounts of good.² These analyses claim that the good for any individual is roughly what he or she would desire under certain ideally informed circumstances. Informed-desire accounts are not unique to contemporary moral philosophers, however; Aristotle's account of the good life as activity in accord with virtue, and his account of virtue in terms of a how a person of practical wisdom would choose from among options concerned with acting or feeling, also indicate an informed-desire analysis.³

² See James Griffin, *Wellbeing* (Oxford: Clarendon Press), 1988, and Peter Railton, "Facts and Values", in *Phil Topics* XIV, No. 2, Fall 1986.

³ *Nichomachean Ethics*, 1098a17 and 1107a.

Though such analyses of good are difficult to work out with precision, a rough account will serve for the purposes of this discussion: the good for a person is what that individual would choose, were he or she adequately or deeply informed of all his or her options. Without yet attending to any of the philosophical difficulties involved in this rough account, we can write a quick prescription for the attainment of the good life when conceived of as the one we would pick were we aware of all that is possible for us. To live as well as possible, on such an account, we should 1) become acquainted with all of our options, 2) identify those possibilities we would prefer to obtain, and 3) become able to obtain what we have chosen. Just below I will suggest that these three steps form the basis of a useful account of the nature of education. Before making that case, though, at least some of the more glaring difficulties with the naive account of good I have presented need to be addressed.

It is of course abundantly clear that no human being can know all his or her options. The sort of information we seek to obtain about our options in ordinary practical reasoning is knowledge of what it would be like to live out each option, together with knowledge of the associated costs and benefits of each option. Options, after all, come in sets, and we do not choose them in isolation from one another. Becoming a Buddhist, for example, involves more than accepting a set of doctrines; it is in part to embark on the pursuit of a number of objectives related to achieving victory over oneself. The practical implications of pursuing those goals are innumerable. The difficulty involved in gaining a rich awareness of what it would be like to live out any given option we might contemplate is overwhelming. The magnitude of the information-gathering aspects of practical reasoning is seen to be even more foreboding when one considers that the information relevant to any given choice is more than that which we might use to give a verbal description of any given option.

A vast amount of background knowledge, including knowledge of conceptual frameworks within which our options both are and might otherwise be conceived, and self-knowledge including knowledge of what our character and values are and might become, is also relevant to any given choice. For when we choose, we reinforce or ratify both our conceptual formation as well as our character and values. It is always possible, when confronted with any given set of options, to choose to work toward adopting a radically different way of conceiving of our situation, and toward becoming a different kind of person with a different sort of character. Becoming a dedicated Marxist and rejecting capitalist lures is an option of which many people are aware, and what it would be like to adopt some such revolutionary route is always relevant to whether continuing on the road to Certified Public Accountancy is a good thing—a thing, that is, one would choose were one to have a rich acquaintance with all of one's current options.

We cannot possibly know all of our options, including what it would be like to think and act in ways characteristic of all of the different sorts of persons each of us individually might become. It is clear, then, that our choices cannot be made to respond to all of the sort of information about our options which we nonetheless seek to maximally obtain in our practical decision-making—at least not if that information is stored cognitively. It is possible, however, for the choices of an individual to be made to respond to more information about how he or she would choose under better-informed circumstances than that person has himself or herself has yet acquired. A child can be taught not to cross the street without first stopping, looking, and listening, long before that child has gathered the requisite sorts of experiences to confirm that such a policy is indeed the one he or she would choose in light of experience he or she later has. Other people can create a field of options for us, and can by controlling the pattern of our experience form us in particular

ways. In the very use of language, the concepts we will use to organize our experience are given to us by others. Similar control over our choices can be exercised by those in a position to produce in us the kind of habits, and thus the character, which they think we would choose, were we to have the sorts of experienced which they have had. We begin making our own choices on a field of play, as it were, which others have created for us, intentionally or otherwise. An injunction against lying serves well as an example. Knowing what counts as a lie, as well as our disposition toward telling or avoiding them, was given to us by others normally with the expectation that what we were being given was for our own good.

All human beings control the environment of their very young in this way, and let us for our purposes restrict our consideration to those who intend only the benefit of the young in so doing. How long this sort of control will be exercised for the benefit of the young will depend on how much the controlling parties believe they know about how the younger and controlled persons would choose were they some day to have the requisite kinds of experiences; it depends, that is, on how much they think they know about what is good for these young persons. Because we know little about the very young as individuals, what is good for the young will typically have to be inferred from claims about what is good for just any human being. Of course, different sorts of traditions have thought very different things about how similar human beings are with respect to what is good for them. Thus, some traditions have sought to shelter and thus control the options presented to the less mature members of their societies to greater extents than have others. But to control the way options are presented to the young is to control their education.

Plato's *Republic* is perhaps the *locus classicus* for a discussion of the more rigid extreme on the range of different attitudes toward the control of education; certain

voices in children's rights movements from our own society represent perhaps the other extreme. Traditions which have had greater confidence in the basic similarity of human beings with respect to what they would pick under better-informed circumstances will claim that the process whereby the accumulated practical wisdom of many generations is passed on to succeeding generations takes a considerable number of years. One can understand the old Roman Catholic practice of placing books on the index--the list of those not to be read by the ordinary faithful--as reflecting a confidence that maturity in wisdom and holiness in that tradition is usually not achieved even by most adults in that tradition.

III.

It does seem possible to get the choices of individuals to respond to information about their own good without their first having to have personal experience of the relevant options. It would seem, then, that if the aim of education is the achievement of the good life for those being educated, the form that education will take for different traditions will depend upon how much information about the good life the mature members of each tradition believe can be stored noncognitively through the formation of the conceptual scheme and character of less mature members of their traditions.⁴ To understand this dependence more clearly, let us utilize the three-fold framework for education discussed earlier to consider the impact on education of different beliefs about the ideal route to the good life.

⁴ For Donald Davidson's objections to one of the notions at work here, see "On the Very Idea of a Conceptual Scheme" in *Truth and Interpretation* (Oxford: Oxford University Press) 1984; MacIntyre's replies can be found in *Whose Justice? Which Rationality?*, chapter XIX, and *Three Rival Versions of Moral Enquiry*, chapter V.

That three-fold framework, again, is this: to achieve what is best in life, one must first become adequately acquainted with one's options; secondly, determine one's preferences from among them; and thirdly, become able to achieve those which have been identified as best. Now since the formation of character depends upon the selective and orderly presentation of options (thereby removing what are considered temptations which are either too strong or too subtle for less mature members to resist), the presentation of the range of options possible for the student will require a more precise ordering in proportion to a tradition's belief in the amount of good which can be done to the student through the formation of character. One might imagine traditions which think that deep and genuine acquaintance with the life and thought of rival traditions is of real benefit to its mature members, but not to its less mature members as long as they are less mature. Both Plato and Aristotle can be seen to have exemplified this approach, since in their own writings they paid serious attention to their predecessors and rivals, yet in their advice about education they urged that virtue must be acquired through imitation by those not yet in a position to judge the merits of the form of life they are imitating.⁵ Gradual exposure to the various studies which reveal human possibilities by exploring human nature and its environment—the liberal arts and sciences—will be thought by members of traditions like these to be of benefit to less mature members, but the kind of exposure needed may be thought to be orderly and compatible with the maturation of character. In this way both the moral and intellectual insights of preceding generations can be passed on to new generations who, once mature, will be able to add their own contributions.⁶ Education in the natural sciences has been claimed by MacIntyre and others to proceed in a similar

⁵ See Aristotle's *Nicomachean Ethics*, 1105a22, and (for example) Plato's remarks on the education of judges in the *Republic*, 409a-c.

⁶ Again, Plato's *Republic*, book IV, 424a provides a classic statement of the hope embodied in traditions of this sort.

pattern: students who make progress in chemistry, physics and biology have typically not been given free reign to discover their own problem areas, instruments, and theories, nor have they normally spent much time seriously exploring the merits of rival paradigms. These sorts of activities are thought to be fruitfully undertaken only by mature members of various scientific disciplines, though according to philosopher and historian of science Thomas Kuhn such activities do not normally characterize life even at the highest levels of maturity in scientific communities.⁷

The information on which human beings seek to ground their choices--information about what it would be like to experience certain options and about how one would choose given such information--lies far beyond the grasp of an individual's own efforts, but an individual's choices can be made to respond to such information (given certain assumptions about our common human nature) through the efforts of others to form the individual's character and beliefs. Because an individual's choices can be made to respond to this advantageous sort of information through this sort of formation, exposure to just any options in just any order will not be viewed by all traditions as advantageous to their less mature members. The recommended order of exposure to and the estimation of the importance of various questions in the different disciplines--indeed, even the demarcation of different disciplines--will vary from one tradition to another, then. Theology should first be studied in classes on Doctrine, and rival world religions studied only later in courses on Apologetics, according to the perspectives of some religious traditions. Other traditions will suppose that World Religions are best taken as historical and

⁷ MacIntyre makes some such suggestion in lecture XX of *Whose Justice? Which Rationality?* (p. 400) and in lecture X of *Three Rival Traditions of Moral Enquiry* (esp. p. 225). Thomas Kuhn has described scientific education as a tightly-ordered process of initiation: see *The Structure of Scientific Revolutions*, 2nd ed. (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1962, 1970) (esp. ch. 2 and ch. 8)

anthropological data to be considered in whatever order is suggested by whichever scholars members of those other traditions esteem as masters of those disciplines.

Just as the educational effort to informatively present students with a range of options for their lives will for different traditions take different forms in ways just described, so too will the process of student assessment of those options be approached differently from the perspectives of different traditions.⁸ Since human beings are not able to acquire on their own all of the experiential knowledge relevant to their own choices, people's choices are inescapably and deeply dependent upon language and character formation. Assessment of options always involves some measure of growing to maturity as a participant in a community. According to some traditions, the sort of formation required for mature membership in their traditions is such that even biologically very young members--say, members having reached puberty--have typically undergone all of the formation which mature members believe to be universally beneficial. We tend to think in our own society that all children should be taught to read if they are able to learn. Not everyone in our pluralistic society would maintain that all children should be taught to wait until marriage to engage in sexual intercourse, however, or to give a substantial portion of their income to the poor, or to accept religious doctrines on the basis of authority.

⁸ Assessment of options as good will surely be different for traditions with informed-desire accounts of good, than for traditions with alternate notions of good (where the good is identified with pleasure, or mere preference, or as a primitive unanalysable property, or as the object of rational desires, or the like.) Even for those traditions which were to accept some version of the informed-desire account underlying the account I have sketched of the nature of education, however, the process of assessment will be different among them. Those of such traditions supposing that human beings have more in common with respect to how they would choose under certain sorts of circumstances will lean more heavily toward language and character formation in education, than will those traditions which suppose human beings to either have less in common with respect to how they would choose, or to be unable to know much about whatever human beings do have in common.

Some traditions to a greater degree than others will have a commitment to form their less mature members prior to the time when those members become mature and are thus able to profit from autonomous choice as they become aware of their options. Thus it is possible that, for many traditions, moral education even at the college level will consist in part in the formation of a particular kind of character. This kind of approach to moral education stands in sharp contrast with the approaches of other traditions, for whom moral education at such a level consists primarily in equipping students with the concepts and skills necessary to sharpen and articulate their already-formed values in the language of contemporary moral discourse.⁹

The third task in the educational framework we are considering is that of becoming able to obtain those options of which the student became aware as part of the first task and which the student assessed as part of the second. Again, for all traditions this third task will involve some measure of conceptual and moral formation. Again, in those traditions whose mature members are committed to supposing a greater degree of similarity regarding the good life for human beings there will be a commitment to a greater degree of such formation. The skills and the virtues necessary for becoming a mature member of one's tradition will vary from tradition to tradition.

IV.

The conclusion that education is inescapably tradition-bound in the way I have just described has enormous implications for higher education in general, and for

⁹ For a discussion of theories of moral development--William Perry's, Lawrence Kohlberg's, and James Rest's--and their impact on a moral education as conceived of from various Christian traditions, see Arthur F. Holmes' *Shaping Character: Moral Education in the Christian College* (Grand Rapids: Eerdmans Publishing Company) 1991, especially chapter two.

common and core curricula in particular, implications which can only be sketched here.

Just as no tradition-neutral education is possible for individuals, no such neutrality can be embodied in the structure of educational institutions. To suppose that education is some neutral, tradition-independent inquiry into rival traditions is to embody the commitments of a particular tradition, one which in its approach to education is distinguished from other traditions by its lack of awareness of its own nature as a particular tradition.¹⁰

If tradition-neutral education is impossible in the way I have described here, what is needed are institutions with a clear grasp of the assumptions embodied in their approaches to education, and thus of the tradition or plurality of traditions embodied in those institutions. Only when institutions are reflective and articulate about their educational commitments in this way will they be able to contribute to the urgent human task of fostering a dialogue, a contest, among rival traditions.

The anti-neutrality thesis advanced here seems at first glance to imply an inescapable relativism regarding the good life, and thus regarding education. MacIntyre's recent efforts have been dedicated to showing that the possibility of rational consensus among inhabitants of rival traditions is not undermined by the tradition-bound nature of rational inquiry. He argues that it is possible that for any

¹⁰ MacIntyre discusses the emergence of what he calls the "liberal university", one which he claims exemplifies this lack of awareness, in Lecture X of *Three Rival Versions of Moral Enquiry*. See also Lecture XVII of his *Whose Justice? Which Rationality?*. This sort of lack of awareness is MacIntyre's main charge against various "great books" versions of curriculum reform currently advocated by—for example—Allan Bloom and William J. Bennett. See *Three Rival Versions of Moral Enquiry*, esp. pp. 228 ff.

two rival traditions you pick, the mature inhabitants of both traditions might come to prefer the same tradition of the two, were they to become immersed in one another's traditions as what MacIntyre calls second first-language speakers. Since they have been originally formed in rival traditions, these bilingual investigators will at first have different reasons for preferring the same tradition of the two, but may nonetheless come to share a common tradition. The possible reasons for which such choices among traditions might be made are catalogued by MacIntyre in the concluding chapter of *Whose Justice? Which Rationality?*--aptly titled "Contested Justices, Contested Rationalities"--and fall outside the scope of the present discussion. The point at issue here is that there are reasons for supposing that rival traditions can be rationally improved and rationally evaluated in a context of cross-traditional investigation. Institutions of higher education are needed which will provide fora for such conversations to take place among mature members of rival traditions.

For such conversations to be effective, it is necessary that there *be* mature members of rival traditions. It is possible that any tradition with its accumulated wisdom be lost not because its mature members defect from or revolutionize their own tradition into new or previously existing alternate traditions, but because the conditions necessary for the maturation of a tradition's members no longer obtain. Two important currents at work in contemporary higher education would seem to undercut the conditions necessary for the formation of mature members in many important rival traditions.

The first of these currents is the attempt to force multicultural and thus multitradeitional diversity into every level of education, and especially higher education. Catering to the educational aspirations of students formed in different

traditions is incompatible with the ordered presentation of ideas and communal experiences essential to the conceptual and character formation constituting maturation in a given tradition. The kind of conversation and the resulting conceptual and moral formation possible among a group of aspiring Marxists or Christians and mature members of their own traditions will be quite different from the kind of conversation held among a diverse group of students who do not share the fundamental commitments of a single tradition. Both kinds of conversation are necessary components of education in such traditions, but only the latter sort of conversation will be had in educational environments characterized everywhere by diversity.

No less destructive of a student's formation in a single tradition is the appearance of objectivity and neutrality in rational investigation promoted by many who oppose the now-fashionable emphasis on multicultural diversity. To treat just anyone capable of abstract reasoning as a peer in the quest for truth is to insist on minimizing the impact of the sort of formation which many traditions have labored to instill in their members. Perhaps no such formation beyond a readily-achievable level is really beneficial to human beings; that, however, is a conclusion to be reached in the dialogue among traditions, and not a premise to be assumed before the dialogue even starts.

If the main parties to the current debate over diversity enacted their programmes, the net result would be that the sort of diversity which is beneficial in the quest for truth and for the good life would be impossible to achieve. The kind of diversity we need is a diversity of traditions situated in contexts which both enable them to survive—unless their own mature members abandon them—and which enable mature members of those traditions to learn from one another. Most contemporary

institutions of higher education are unreflective about their own traditional commitments and corrosive of rival traditions, contributing little toward any potentially fruitful dialogue among rival traditions. We need new models for higher education.

What, then, of core curricula? The plain implication of the preceding reflections is that core curricula will vary with the educational objectives of particular traditions. The precise effects on the core of recognizing the tradition-bound nature of education will differ from one tradition to another, and are the subject of another discussion. Given the increasingly pluralistic nature of our society, though, the tradition-bound nature of education has at least this one particular sort of implication for the future of core curricula. It will be increasingly important to recognize oneself as an inhabitant of a particular tradition, or as having been raised at the intersection of some number of rival traditions. It will be important to understand the difference between formation within a tradition for the sake of one's own advancement in wisdom, and indoctrination by a tradition for the sake of someone else. It will also be important to understand the process by which rival traditions can engage in fruitful dialogue. The acquisition of skills such as these are likely to become part of any tradition's efforts equip its members with the sorts of skills its mature members think less mature members need to achieve the good life, the central goal of education.

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